

Password Strength Activity

Updated June 2026 for mobile readability and standards-review clarity.

Password Strength Activity

Cybersecurity & Digital Ethics Starter Kit | Student Activity

Security skills should help students protect people, systems, and information.

Password Strength Activity

Student Activity

Audience: Students | Grades 8-12

Purpose

- Do not write, share, test, or submit a real password. Use only fictional examples created for class.

Student-safe note

- Use fictional examples. Do not use real passwords, real accounts, live suspicious links, or private information.

Standards summary

- This resource may support CSF 13.1, CSF 14.1, CSF 14.3.
- Detailed alignment depends on local district pacing, approved course placement, and teacher directions.

Important Safety Rule

Do not write, share, test, or submit a real password. Use only fictional examples created for class.

Main Ideas

- Long passphrases are usually stronger and easier to remember than short complex passwords.
- Reusing the same password across accounts creates risk.
- Multi-factor authentication adds protection if a password is stolen.
- Password managers can help users store strong unique passwords safely.
- No one should ask for your password in a message, chat, or email.

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Part 1: Evaluate the Examples

Fictional Example

Rating

Reason

tigers

Weak

Too short and easy to guess

Tigers2026!

Better but still risky

Uses a common pattern and school/team

clue

Blue-River-Pizza-Clou

d-77

Stronger

Longer passphrase with unrelated words

SamePasswordEvery

where!

Risky

Reuse across sites creates major risk

Part 2: Build a Safer Passphrase Pattern

Create a fictional passphrase pattern using unrelated words. Do not use personal information, pet names, birthdays, school names, sports teams, or anything you really use.

Fictional passphrase example:

Why it is stronger: _____

Part 3: Account Protection Reflection

- Why is password reuse dangerous?
- How does multi-factor authentication help?
- Why should you avoid sharing passwords, verification codes, or recovery codes?
- What should you do if you think an account has been compromised?

Exit Ticket

One password habit I should avoid:

One stronger account habit I can use:

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Detailed Tennessee Standards Connection

Tennessee Standards Connection

This activity supports standards when students connect account protection, access control, confidentiality, and safe security practices to everyday technology use.

Standards source: Tennessee Department of Education, Computer Science Foundations (C10H11), May 2023. Confirm final alignment against local district pacing, approved course placement, and teacher directions.

This resource may support the following Tennessee standards when used as part of cybersecurity, digital ethics, computer science, AI literacy, or career-connected technology instruction:

- CSF 13.1 - Social, Legal, and Ethical Issues: Students research social, legal, and ethical issues encountered by IT professionals and identify responsibilities when addressing technology problems.
- CSF 14.1 - Data Security: Students explain why data security is a priority and demonstrate understanding of confidentiality, availability, and integrity.
- CSF 14.3 - Security Practices: Students identify security practices for computer and network systems, including access control, encryption techniques, BIOS features, and malware response strategies.

Item

Details

Estimated Time

30-45 minutes

Purpose

Help students understand why strong passwords, passphrases, multi-factor authentication, and safe account habits matter.

Student Product

Password safety analysis, stronger passphrase example, and reflection.

Use guidance

- Confirm final alignment against local district pacing, approved course placement, and teacher directions.
- Keep instruction defensive, ethical, age-appropriate, and classroom-safe.

Standards Review Standards review note (June 2026): Tennessee Computer Science Foundations course standards (C10H11) remain published by the Tennessee Department of Education as May 2023 standards. Standards references in this resource are intended as cautious instructional alignment notes; final alignment should be confirmed against local district pacing, course placement, and current district guidance.